

#### SECTION FOUR

## ECONOMY, LABOUR & RESOURCES

*Money makes the world go round, even fantasy worlds. Economics determines who eats and who starves, who has power and who serves, who gets to choose their life and who never had a choice to begin with. It shapes what people do all day, what they aspire to, and what they're willing to sacrifice. And in romantasy, economics is the invisible force that tilts every relationship before it even begins.*

# The Invisible Ledger Principle

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Every relationship contains a ledger. Not literally, but every time someone pays for a meal, saves another person's life, provides shelter, or gives a gift, a line is added. Both parties know the ledger exists, and no one wants to be the party owing more.

This is the Invisible Ledger, and it's the engine that drives economic tension in romantasy.

The ledger exists because love is expected to be free, yet everything costs. If one person has more wealth, power, or resources, the ledger is already skewed before they get involved romantically. The character on the wrong side of the ledger feels it, even if they can't articulate it. It causes pride when they should accept aid, suspicion when they should feel gratitude. It forces them to wonder: *Do I love them, or am I in love with what they have invested in me?*

The ledger can be based on money, magical power, social status, or political protection. What matters is that there is an inequality, and both parties are tracking it, even when they pretend they're not. The romantic turning point comes when one or both characters decide to stop counting. Not when the debt is paid, but when it stops mattering.

Keep this principle in mind as you work through the exercises below. First, you'll build the economic foundation of your world. Then, once you know how your economy works, you'll return to the Invisible Ledger and map how it applies to your specific characters and romance.

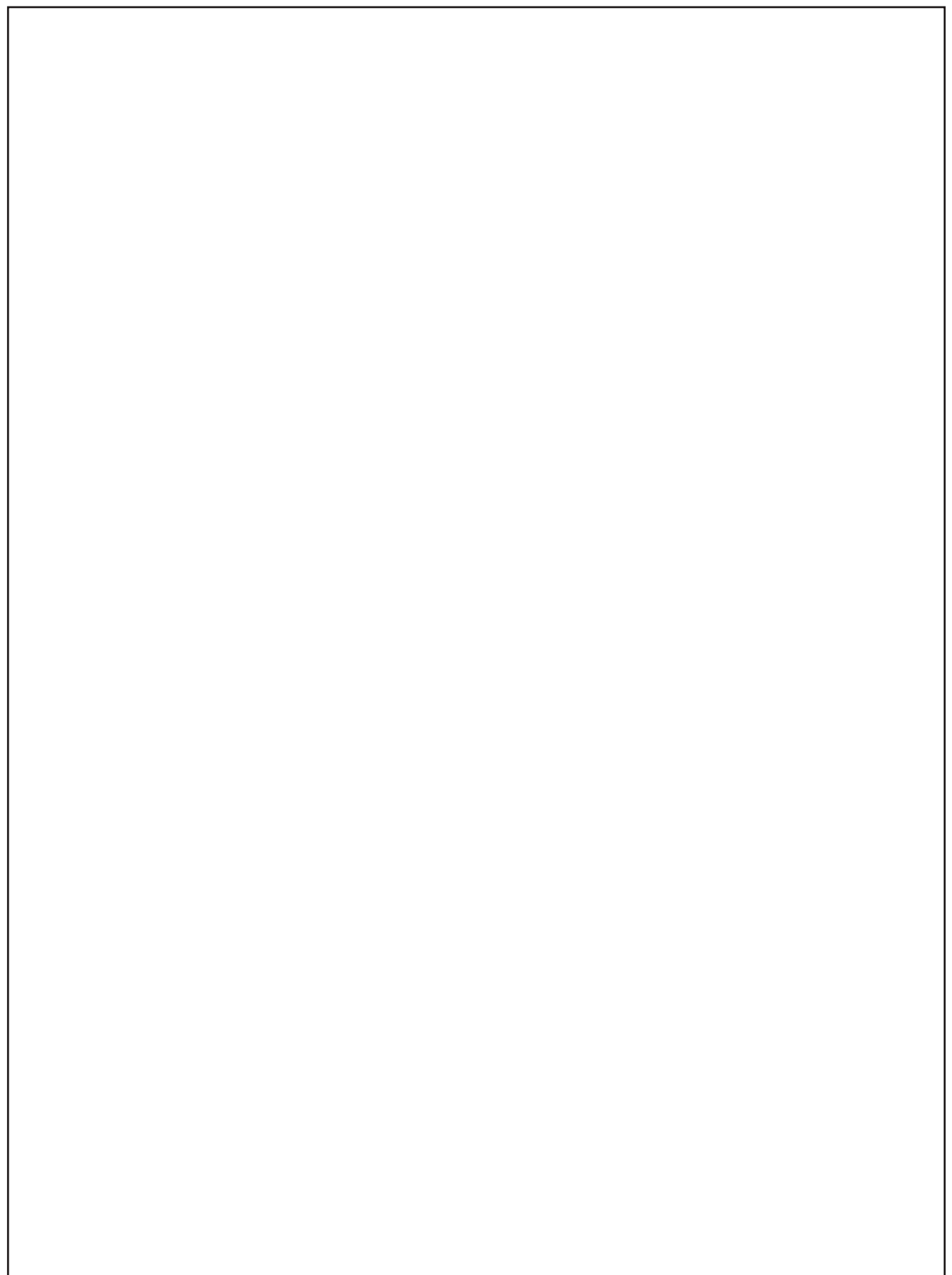
**Before you dive into the details, get the big picture down. What does the economic landscape of your world look like?**

*Don't overthink this. Just describe the general feel: is it a world of abundance or scarcity? Are there vast wealth gaps or relative equality? Is trade thriving or stagnant? Are people mostly farmers, merchants, soldiers, artisans? You'll refine all of this in the exercises that follow. For now, capture your instinct.*

*(Write your answer below)*

**What is the single biggest economic pressure shaping daily life in your world right now?**

*War taxes? Famine? A trade embargo? A magical resource drying up? Name the pressure that ordinary people feel, because that pressure will also press on your characters and their relationship.*  
*(Write your answer below)*



## A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't.

If your world mirrors a historical economy, focus on what's different. Zero in on what deviates from reader expectations and what specifically creates tension for your romance.

Economics can stay in the background. If your obstacles are political, magical, or cultural rather than economic, develop just enough economy to make the world feel real.

### Quick Guide to What You Need

**Every story needs:** A basic economic system, what currency exists, what your characters do for work, and how wealth shapes daily life.

**If your romance involves a wealth gap:** Focus on the Wealth Gap Dynamic and Money/Gifts sections.

**If your romance involves economic coercion or arranged marriage:** Focus on Marriage as Economic Contract and Debt & Obligation.

**If your world has a magic-based economy:** Don't skip "If Your Economy Runs on Magic."

**If your romance involves employer/employee dynamics:** Focus on The Employer & The Employed and Economic Independence.

**If you're not sure yet:** Start with the Brain Dump and Economic Systems. You can always come back.

### How to Use This Section

Questions marked ♦ **Core** are the foundations. Answer these first and you'll have a working economy for your world. Everything else lets you go deeper where your story needs it. If you're short on time, the Core questions alone will get you writing.

## Common Mistakes with Economic Worldbuilding

### Mistake #1: The Meaningless Wealth Gap

One character is rich and one is poor, but it never affects anything. The poor character has no financial pressures. Economic difference creates stakes only when it has real consequences.

#### FIX

Make the gap mean something. The poor character faces real scarcity. The rich character's money affects the power dynamic.

### Mistake #2: The Infinite Wealth

The wealthy character can buy their way out of any problem. Money is never actually a constraint. Stakes require constraints. If wealth solves everything, the story loses tension.

#### FIX

Give wealth limits. Their money is tied up, controlled by family, or comes with strings. Or money simply can't solve this particular problem.

### Mistake #3: The Invisible Economy

Characters exist in an economic vacuum. Nobody seems to work or worry about money. **Check your work against the common mistakes.** *These three traps catch even experienced writers. Be honest: if you spot one, that's a good thing. It means you can fix it now rather than three drafts from now.* | Mistake | Am I Doing This? | How I'll Fix It | |—|—|—| | *The Meaningless Wealth Gap: one character is rich, one is poor, but it never affects anything* | Yes, my FMC is poor but it only comes up in chapter 1 | Add a scene where she can't afford medicine and has to accept help from the love interest, triggering a pride spiral | | *The Meaningless Wealth Gap: one character is rich, one is poor, but it never creates consequences* | | | *The Infinite Wealth: the wealthy character can buy their way out of any problem* | | | *The Invisible Economy: nobody seems to work or worry about money* | | |

#### FIX

Ground characters in economic reality. Readers should understand how they survive. Choices have economic consequences.

## Economic Systems

### ♦ Core: What type of economy exists in your world?

Think about how the economic system shapes daily life and what opportunities exist for your characters. Does it allow for social mobility, or are people locked into their station?

| TYPE            | ✓ | HOW WEALTH WORKS                                     | HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE                                                |
|-----------------|---|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Feudal/Agrarian |   | Land-based wealth; peasants work land owned by lords | Rigid class barriers between lovers; land as dowry or inheritance; a |

| TYPE              | ✓ | HOW WEALTH WORKS                                          | HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE                                                                                                                |
|-------------------|---|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                   |   |                                                           | character's worth tied to what they own                                                                                              |
| Mercantile/Trade  |   | Wealth from commerce; merchant class rising               | New money vs. old blood tension; a merchant who can buy anything except status; trade routes that create distance                    |
| Guild-Based       |   | Professions controlled by guilds; must apprentice         | Forbidden to marry outside the guild; apprentice/master power dynamics; secrets that can't be shared with outsiders                  |
| Magical Economy   |   | Magic is primary source of wealth/production              | Magical ability as class marker; a non-magical partner seen as "marrying down"; one character's power literally sustaining the other |
| Scarcity/Survival |   | Resources desperately scarce; survival is primary concern | Love as luxury you can't afford; choosing a partner for survival rather than desire; sharing resources as intimacy                   |

Which type (or combination) describes your world?

*Your economic system determines what obstacles exist for your characters. A feudal economy locks them into class; a guild economy locks them into profession. Name it so you can build from it.*

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Core: What does a normal workday look like for an ordinary person in your world?**

*Pick someone who isn't royalty or a chosen one: a farmer, a shopkeeper, a dockworker. What time do they wake up? What do they do all day? What do they eat? How much do they earn? This is your economic baseline, and everything else in this section builds on it.*

YOUR ANSWER

**How is wealth created in your world?**

*The source of wealth determines who has it, and who your characters have to fight, serve, or charm to get it. A world where wealth comes from magic creates different romantic obstacles than one where wealth comes from land.*

Agriculture? Trade? Craftsmanship? Mining? Magic? Conquest?



YOUR ANSWER

### **How is wealth distributed?**

*Concentrated wealth means a wider gap between your leads, and more people invested in keeping them apart.*

Relatively equal? Concentrated among few? Regional variation? Class-based?

YOUR ANSWER

### **♦ Core: How does wealth inequality show up in everyday life?**

*Think about what a stranger would notice walking through your world. Do rich and poor people dress differently? Live in different parts of town? Eat different food? The visible markers of wealth tell the reader (and your characters) who belongs where.*

YOUR ANSWER

### **How does wealth move?**

*If wealth can only be inherited, your poor character can't earn their way up. Marriage or magic might be the only paths. If wealth can be earned, ambition becomes a romantic complication.*

Can it be earned through work? Only inherited? Granted by rulers? Won through conquest?

YOUR ANSWER

### **Economic Conditions**

**Is the economy currently stable, growing, or in crisis?**

Prosperity? Slow decline? Post-war rebuilding? Famine or shortage? On the brink of collapse?

YOUR ANSWER

**What economic pressures affect ordinary people right now?**

Inflation? Scarcity? Heavy taxation? Unemployment? War disruption?

YOUR ANSWER

**What choice is the current economy forcing on your characters?**

*A war economy, famine, or recession doesn't just set the backdrop. It creates urgency. If the world is collapsing, falling in love might feel irresponsible, or it might be the only thing worth holding onto.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What do people in your world trade, and how do trade routes work?**

*Trade routes shape where people travel, who they meet, and what's available. A character on a trade route sees the world; a character far from one might never leave home. Think about what gets moved, who moves it, and which roads or sea lanes connect your major settlements.*

YOUR ANSWER

**Who controls the trade routes, and what power does that give them?**

*Whoever controls where goods move controls who profits. A family that holds a mountain pass, a guild that owns the river barges, a navy that patrols the shipping lanes. They decide who trades and who starves. If your characters are on opposite sides of that control, the economy itself becomes an obstacle between them.*

YOUR ANSWER

**How does the economy differ between regions?**

*A port city and a mountain village probably have very different economic realities. Prices, available goods, common jobs, and levels of wealth can all shift from one region to the next. Where your characters come from shapes what they consider normal.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What does a market or trading hub look like in your world?**

*Markets are where your economy becomes visible and sensory. What stalls line the streets? What smells fill the air? What's shouted, haggled over, displayed under lock and key? A market scene grounds your world's economy in something the reader can picture, and it's a natural setting for characters to cross paths.*

YOUR ANSWER

### If Your Economy Runs on Magic

When magic serves as the economy (as labour, as currency, as the determinant of who eats and who starves), each person's body and power becomes the commodity. You need to determine how your magical system creates economic winners and losers.

#### How is magical power produced?

Magic has to come from somewhere, and where it comes from determines who pays the cost. There are broadly three models:

| MODEL           | HOW IT WORKS                                                       | WHO BENEFITS                                      | WHO PAYS                                      | ROMANTASY EXAMPLE                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Magic as labour | Power is generated through personal effort, exertion, or sacrifice | Those with endurance, training, or natural talent | The individual wizard; their body is the fuel | In Naomi Novik's <i>Scholomance</i> , mana is produced through physical and mental drudgery. Every spell costs somebody's effort. The fitter you get, the harder you have to work to generate the |

| MODEL                | HOW IT WORKS                                                                                      | WHO BENEFITS                                        | WHO PAYS                                                                 | ROMANTASY EXAMPLE                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                      |                                                                                                   |                                                     |                                                                          | same mana.<br>There's no shortcut.                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Magic as inheritance | Power passes through bloodlines, is gifted by the land, or is biologically determined             | Those born into the right family, species, or caste | Everyone excluded by birth                                               | In <i>ACOTAR</i> , the High Fae inherit magical power through blood. High Lords are chosen by the land's magic itself. The Lesser Fae are structurally locked into servant roles regardless of individual merit. |
| Magic as commodity   | Power is stored in objects, substances, or transferable units that can be bought, sold, or stolen | Those with wealth to purchase magical materials     | Those forced to sell their power, their labour, or their very life force | In Sanderson's <i>Stormlight Archive</i> , currency is literally gemstones infused with magical energy. In <i>Warbreaker</i> , every person is born with one Breath that can be sold, meaning the                |

| MODEL | HOW IT WORKS | WHO BENEFITS | WHO PAYS | ROMANTASY EXAMPLE                      |
|-------|--------------|--------------|----------|----------------------------------------|
|       |              |              |          | wealthy can buy the souls of the poor. |

The type of model you use will have major effects on the development of the romance in your story. If magic is labour, then a very strong character is also a very tired character and the romantic partner that gives them a break from all they are doing, that assists them, that recognises the price they pay for that great spell, is going to be an important part of the story in a very personal way. If magic is based on birthright, your romance is working against a social caste system. When a person with magical ability falls in love with someone that is considered beneath them socially, they risk losing their own standing within society. And if magic is a commodity, love can be confused with commerce: is a gift of magical power an act of love or an act of purchase? In *Fourth Wing*, the state controls magical labour absolutely. Navarre funnels its magically gifted citizens through Basgiath War College, where dragon riders become elite military assets and everyone else becomes expendable infantry. You don't get to decide if you're going to be a dragon rider or not; it's decided for you and you can lose your life in this decision. In the *Scholomance*, Enclaves are analogous to corporations: the wealthy class lives safely behind magical barriers and the independently operating wizards give up their magical abilities in exchange for a secure place to live. The pattern continues to repeat itself. Those at the top of the structure accumulate the majority of the magical resources. Those at the bottom of the structure do the hard, dangerous work.

### **What happens to people without magic?**

An economy based on magic means people who don't have it aren't just financially impoverished. They're structurally excluded.

Jude in *The Cruel Prince* is a human living in Elfhome, a world where the Fae can glamour humans into mindless servants, stripping them of will and identity. Being non-magical puts Jude at a risk of being enslaved, which goes beyond mere poverty. The only advantages she has over the Fae are that she can lie (the Fae can't) and she's been trained to fight. When she falls for Cardan, a Fae prince, there is more than just an emotional difference between them. It's existential. He belongs to the species that can erase her mind with a thought.

In *ACOTAR*, the social hierarchy is based on biology: the High Fae are beautiful, powerful, long-lived, and legally protected. The Lesser Fae are responsible for all of the menial jobs such as cooking, cleaning, and maintenance. When Hybern attacks the Summer Court, the High Fae lock themselves in the upper areas of the kingdom and leave the Lesser Fae in the lower areas to be killed. The message is loud and clear. All that matters is how much magical blood runs through your veins.

If magic can be extracted, stored, or stolen, then magical characters aren't just workers. They're resources. The level of romantic tension present in these novels is extreme: does your love interest view you as a person or a potential resource?

**What happens to people without magic in your world?**

*If your economy runs on magic, people who lack it aren't just poor. They're structurally locked out. What does this mean for daily survival? If one of your leads is ungifted while the other is powerful, the gap between them isn't just financial. It's existential.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What barriers does your magic system put between lovers?**

Think about the specific barriers your magic system creates:

| BARRIER                   | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE                                              | QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE                                               |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Biological essentialism   | Power determined by species, bloodline, or birth                | Can your characters have children? Would their children be “less than”? |
| Institutional gatekeeping | Access to magic controlled by schools, military, guilds         | Does the institution forbid relationships across rank or quadrant?      |
| Economic exclusion        | Magic costs money to fuel or access                             | Can the less wealthy character ever be an equal partner?                |
| Lifespan disparity        | Magical beings live centuries; non-magical partners age and die | Is the Fae character watching their human lover grow old?               |



| BARRIER                | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE                             | QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE                                      |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Glamour/mental control | One species can psychically dominate the other | How does the human partner trust that their feelings are real? |

### Can magic create wealth or resources?

*If magic can solve money problems, you need a reason it doesn't, otherwise your characters' economic struggles feel artificial. The limitation you choose here becomes a plot constraint that keeps your romance under pressure.*

Transmuting materials? Summoning resources? Faster production? Healing for pay? Magical transportation?

YOUR ANSWER

### If yes, why isn't everyone rich?

*This is where you close the loophole. The best answers create romantic tension: magic costs something personal (a healer who shortens their own life), magic is restricted by the powerful (a guild that serves the rich), or magic ability is rare (one character has it and the other doesn't, creating envy or dependence).*

Scarcity of mages? Magic costs something (health, lifespan, sanity)? Laws restrict it? Requires rare ability or training?

YOUR ANSWER

### **What magical labour is economically valuable?**

*Magical services people pay for tell you where magical characters sit in the economy, and what they're worth to others. A love interest who's a paid healer has different leverage than one who's a court enchanter.*

What magical services do people pay for?

YOUR ANSWER

### **Who controls magical economic power?**

*Whoever controls magical labour controls magical people. If your mage character answers to a guild, a government, or a magical family, that's a leash on their freedom, and a constraint on who they can love and how openly they can love them.*

Guilds? Government? Individual mages? Magical families?

YOUR ANSWER

*Cross-check: Are these rules consistent with your magic system (Section 8)? If you said magic is rare and exhausting there but cheap and plentiful here, reconcile the two before moving on.*

*Now that you know what your economy runs on, and how magic might complicate it, it's time to make the money feel real. Currency gives readers something to hold onto when wealth and poverty are on the page.*

## Currency & Scale

### ◆ Core: What currency exists?

*You don't need a full monetary system, but knowing what your coins are called and roughly what they're worth lets you write scenes where money feels real. A character counting coppers hits differently than a character vaguely "being poor."*

Coins (what metals, what denominations)? Paper money? Trade goods as currency? Magical currency?

YOUR ANSWER

### What's the rough scale of money?

Readers need to feel the weight of money in your story. What costs would make your protagonist wince, and what would your love interest spend without thinking? You don't need a full monetary system. You need enough for readers to feel the gap when one character drops coins casually and the other counts every one.

| ITEM                        | APPROXIMATE COST |
|-----------------------------|------------------|
| Day's unskilled labour wage |                  |

| ITEM                        | APPROXIMATE COST |
|-----------------------------|------------------|
| Simple meal                 |                  |
| Night at an inn             |                  |
| A decent horse              |                  |
| A year's comfortable living |                  |

*Examples:*

| ITEM                        | APPROXIMATE COST                                    |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Day's unskilled labour wage | 5 copper pieces; a skilled craftsman earns 2 silver |
| Simple meal                 | 2 copper at a tavern; 1 copper from a street vendor |

### **What's your currency called?**

A few details about currency can make your world feel lived-in. What's stamped on a coin tells readers something about who's in power. What materials are used tells them what's valued. Perhaps gold coins show the king's face, or copper tokens bear a guild's symbol. Names often reflect history, rulers, or cultural values. A coin called a "blessing" implies different values than one called a "skull."

| DENOMINATION | MATERIAL | VALUE | WHAT'S DEPICTED |
|--------------|----------|-------|-----------------|
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |
|              |          |       |                 |

*Examples:*

| DENOMINATION | MATERIAL | VALUE       | WHAT'S DEPICTED                                |
|--------------|----------|-------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Crown        | Gold     | 100 coppers | Reigning monarch on front, royal crest on back |
| Talon        | Silver   | 10 coppers  | Griffin clutching a sword                      |
| Bit          | Copper   | Base unit   | Sheaf of wheat                                 |

♦ **Core: How do people conduct trade?**

*The method of trade shapes how your characters interact with money, and with each other. Barter creates face-to-face negotiation. Credit creates invisible debt. Magical contracts create supernatural enforcement. Each one affects the romance differently.*

Coin? Barter? Credit? Letters of exchange? Magical contracts?

YOUR ANSWER

**Are there trade restrictions that matter?**

*Trade restrictions are ready-made romantic obstacles. If the guild says she can't sell to outsiders and he's an outsider, that's a wall between them that neither of them built.*

Guilds controlling who can sell what? Import/export restrictions? Illegal goods?

YOUR ANSWER

**What's one purchase that would mean nothing to your wealthier character but everything to the other?**

*If a night at an inn costs 5 coppers and your protagonist earns 3 coppers a day, the reader instantly understands what it means when the love interest drops a gold crown without thinking. Find the specific price point that makes the gap visceral.*

YOUR ANSWER

**Who controls the currency in your world?**

*Whoever mints the coins or regulates the money supply holds invisible power. A king, a guild, a magical institution. The answer tells you who benefits from the system staying the way it is.*



YOUR ANSWER

*Cross-check: Does your currency system match your government type (Section 5)? A feudal system with a stock market or a tribal society with paper banknotes will feel inconsistent to readers.*

## Wealth & Class

### What does wealth look like at different levels?

Show the gap through concrete details. What does each character's home look like? What do they eat? What small luxuries does one take for granted that the other dreams of?

| LEVEL         | WHAT LIFE LOOKS LIKE |
|---------------|----------------------|
| Wealthy/Elite |                      |
| Comfortable   |                      |
| Getting by    |                      |
| Struggling    |                      |
| Impoverished  |                      |

*Examples:*

| LEVEL         | WHAT LIFE LOOKS LIKE                                                                     |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Wealthy/Elite | Multiple estates, servants for every task, never think about cost, can influence laws    |
| Struggling    | One missed harvest from hunger, mending clothes repeatedly, sharing rooms with strangers |

### Can people change their economic class?

Through work? Marriage? Education? Magical ability? Or is class fixed at birth? The answer to this question determines whether your romance is fighting against a wall or a fence. One can be climbed. The other can't. *Cross-check: Do your class markers here match what you described in Culture & Customs (Section 3)? If you said wealth shows up through clothing and food here, make sure your cultural details reflect the same signals.*

YOUR ANSWER

### What doors does wealth open that money alone doesn't explain?

*Think beyond buying things. Wealth often buys access: to education, political influence, legal protection, better marriage prospects, or simply free time. These invisible advantages shape who your characters can become. Access to education? Political influence? Legal protection? Better marriage prospects? Leisure time?*

YOUR ANSWER

### What can't poor people do, have, or access in your world?

*Get specific. Can they see a healer? Send their children to school? Travel freely? Live safely? The things poverty locks people out of become the stakes of your romance.*

YOUR ANSWER

**If mobility is possible, what's the path?**

*If your characters come from different classes, social mobility is the escape hatch, or the false promise. Can your less wealthy character actually climb, or is the system rigged? This determines whether “we’ll find a way” is realistic or delusional.*

YOUR ANSWER

**If mobility is impossible, what keeps people locked in place?**

*The thing that keeps your characters apart isn't just personal opposition. It's structural. Name the structures. The more specific you get, the harder the obstacle feels, and the more satisfying it is when love finds a way through.*

Legal restrictions? Economic barriers? Social enforcement?

YOUR ANSWER



### ◆ Checkpoint: Economic Foundations

*Pause and look at your answers so far. Does your economic system match the wealth distribution you described? If you said wealth is concentrated among a few, but your system allows easy social mobility, something may need adjusting. Check that your currency, class structure, and economic conditions all point in the same direction.*

## Resources & Scarcity

### Building on Section 1

**Your Resource Foundation** In Section 1: Resources & Territorial Control, you mapped where resources are found and who controls them. Now we'll explore how that control creates economic stakes and romantic tension.

#### ◆ Core: What's the single most valuable resource in your world?

The thing people would kill for, die for, or sell their freedom for. Now ask: does either of your main characters control it, need it, or threaten someone's access to it? That's where the romantic stakes live.

YOUR ANSWER

### Why is it scarce?

*The reason for scarcity tells you who's to blame, and whether your characters are on the same side of that blame. Natural rarity is nobody's fault. Controlled distribution means someone is hoarding, and your characters might be on opposite sides of that injustice.*

Natural rarity? Controlled distribution? Difficult to produce? Dangerous to obtain?

YOUR ANSWER

### What resources are essential for survival?

*Survival needs create desperation, and desperation drives romance plots. If your character can't afford medicine, they might accept help from someone they don't trust. If clean water is controlled by the love interest's family, every sip is a reminder of the power imbalance.*

Food, water, shelter, fuel, medicine. What do people need to live?

YOUR ANSWER

### ◆ Core: What resources are scarce, and who suffers most from the shortage?

*Scarcity doesn't hit everyone equally. The wealthy stockpile; the poor go without. Knowing who suffers tells you where desperation lives in your world, and desperation drives stories.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What conflicts has resource scarcity caused in your world?**

*When something essential is scarce, people fight over it. Those conflicts shape alliances, create enemies, and force your characters to pick sides.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What goods or services are easy to get in your world, and what is hard to find?**

*Abundance and scarcity shape what your characters take for granted and what they crave. A world with plentiful food but no metal has different tensions than one with gold mines but barren soil. The things that are hard to get become leverage, status symbols, or gifts that carry real weight.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What does your world's most important resource change about how people live?**

Resources don't just create cultures. They create the conditions for love stories. Scarcity forces desperate choices. Abundance creates power to hoard or share. Control of a resource is control of people's lives.

| RESOURCE             | HOW IT SHAPES CULTURE                                          | HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE                                                                              |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Timber               | Carpentry valued, forests sacred, wooden architecture          | Territorial disputes separating lovers; sacred forests as forbidden meeting places                 |
| Gold/Precious metals | Mining economy, ornate craftsmanship, wealth displays          | Wealth gap made visible; gold as bride price; miners' dangerous lives                              |
| Wool/Textiles        | Weaving traditions, nomadic herders, vibrant markets           | Nomadic vs. settled tension; textile trade creating travel and distance                            |
| Grain/Agriculture    | Harvest festivals, farming cycles dictate life, land ownership | Land as dowry; failed harvests forcing desperate marriages; harvest festivals as romantic settings |
| Salt                 | Preservation culture, salt mining communities                  | Control of essential resource as political leverage in marriage negotiations                       |
| Fish/Sea             | Coastal culture, sailing traditions, sea worship               | Sailors gone for months; port romances; sea as barrier between lovers                              |
| Gemstones            | Jewellery crafting traditions, gem-based status symbols        | Gems as courtship gifts; mining wealth vs. old nobility; gemstone magic tied to bonds              |

*Resources create wealth, but governments take a cut. How the state extracts from its people shapes what your characters actually keep, and what they resent.*



# Taxation & Government Revenue

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## How does the government fund itself?

*Taxes, tribute, tariffs, and tithes all take from ordinary people. What your characters pay, and to whom, shapes how they feel about the powers that govern them.*

What do ordinary people pay? (Land tax, head tax, harvest tithe, labour conscription, magical tribute?) Who collects it, and how fairly?

YOUR ANSWER

## What happens when people can't pay?

*Seizure of property? Debtor's prison? Forced labour? The consequences of failing to pay reveal how harsh or merciful the system really is, and can drive characters into desperate choices.*

YOUR ANSWER

## Are there taxes or tariffs that specifically affect your characters or their community?

*A border tariff might strangle a merchant's livelihood. A magic-user levy might make gifted people into targets. Name the specific tax pressure your characters feel.*

YOUR ANSWER

# Banking & Credit

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## How does lending work in your world?

*Can people borrow money? From whom? A guild, a temple, a moneylender, a noble patron? What are the terms, and what happens to those who default? Debt is one of the most powerful drivers of romantic tension, and it starts here.*

YOUR ANSWER

## Do formal financial institutions exist?

*Banks, lending houses, temples that hold deposits, merchant exchanges, or is everything informal? The presence or absence of financial institutions determines whether debt is regulated or lawless.*

YOUR ANSWER

# Economic History

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## How did the current economy develop?

*Was there a golden age that's now fading? A recent war that reshuffled who has what? A magical discovery that created new industries? The economy your characters live in was shaped by what came before.*

YOUR ANSWER

## Is the economy in transition?

*Economies rarely sit still. Is an old order collapsing? Is new wealth displacing old power? Are people nostalgic for how things used to be? Economic transition creates winners and losers, and characters on opposite sides of that shift.*

YOUR ANSWER

— ◆ —

*The formal economy (taxes, banks, currency) doesn't reach everyone. Some people survive outside it entirely, and their world operates by different rules.*

## **Informal & Subsistence Economies**

**Who doesn't participate in the formal economy, and how do they survive?**

*Not everyone uses coins or trades in markets. Subsistence farmers, nomadic groups, isolated communities, refugees, the very poor. They may barter, forage, or rely on mutual aid. If your characters come from or encounter these communities, their economic assumptions will clash.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What does the formal economy fail to provide, and how do people fill the gap?**

*Mutual aid networks, communal farming, barter circles, scavenging, charity from temples. The gaps in the official economy tell you where the system breaks down and where different forms of community take over.*

YOUR ANSWER



# Work & Occupations

## Reference: Fantasy Professions & Jobs

Use this list for inspiration. What does each profession contribute to your world, and what romantic friction does it create?

| CATEGORY              | EXAMPLES                                                     | WORLDBUILDING<br>ROLE                                                            | ROMANTIC TENSION                                                                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Nobility & Governance | Lord/lady, steward, ambassador, tax collector, court advisor | Political administration, lawmaking, land management, tax collection             | Duty vs. desire; political marriages; “I can’t be seen with you”                        |
| Military & Combat     | Knight, soldier, guard, mercenary, assassin                  | Defence, territorial control, enforcement of law and order                       | Protector/protected dynamic; deployment and separation; violence as barrier to intimacy |
| Skilled Trades        | Blacksmith, carpenter, tailor, jeweller, glassblower         | Manufacturing goods, maintaining infrastructure, supplying armies and households | Working-class pride vs. noble expectations; craft as love language                      |
| Merchants & Trade     | Shopkeeper, trader, caravan master, innkeeper                | Moving goods between regions, setting prices, connecting communities             | Travel and distance; merchant wealth without status; “you’re buying me”                 |
| Service & Household   | Servant, maid, butler, cook, lady’s maid                     | Maintaining elite households, enabling the leisure class to function             | Power imbalance; secret relationships; “I serve you but I want you”                     |
| Healing & Medicine    | Healer, midwife, herbalist, apothecary                       | Public health, treating injuries and                                             | Caretaker intimacy; touching bodies                                                     |

| CATEGORY                | EXAMPLES                                                               | WORLDBUILDING<br>ROLE                                                                         | ROMANTIC TENSION                                                                          |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                         |                                                                        | disease, childbirth,<br>epidemic response                                                     | professionally; “I<br>healed you, now I<br>can’t stop caring”                             |
| Religious & Spiritual   | Priest, priestess,<br>monk, oracle, shrine<br>maiden                   | Spiritual guidance,<br>record-keeping,<br>education, moral<br>authority                       | Forbidden desire;<br>vows of celibacy;<br>divine duty vs.<br>mortal love                  |
| Magical Professions     | Court mage, hedge<br>witch, enchanter,<br>potion-maker, ward-<br>smith | Magical<br>infrastructure, wards,<br>enchanted goods,<br>divination, military<br>applications | Magic as class<br>marker; bonded<br>service; “my power is<br>the only thing you<br>value” |
| Scholarly & Learned     | Scribe, scholar, tutor,<br>librarian, alchemist                        | Preserving<br>knowledge, educating<br>the next generation,<br>research and<br>innovation      | Intellectual equals<br>from different<br>worlds; tutor/student<br>tension                 |
| Underworld &<br>Shadows | Thief, smuggler, spy,<br>bounty hunter,<br>poisoner                    | Moving contraband,<br>gathering<br>intelligence, filling<br>gaps the legal<br>economy won’t   | Secret lives; moral<br>conflict; “if you knew<br>what I really do”                        |

Work shows on the body and shapes the mind. A blacksmith knows whether metal has been worked well or poorly. A merchant will calculate worth with little effort. A soldier will assess a threat in less than a second. When characters from different work worlds meet, let them discover each other through these competencies.

### **What professions are respected? Looked down upon?**

Occupational status shapes how people are treated and what doors open or close. If your characters have different occupations, how might society view their pairing?

| STATUS                             | OCCUPATIONS |
|------------------------------------|-------------|
| Highly respected                   |             |
| Respectable/<br>ordinary           |             |
| Necessary<br>but<br>low-<br>status |             |
| Disreputable<br>or<br>shameful     |             |

*Examples:*

| STATUS                   | OCCUPATIONS                                                 |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Highly respected         | Court mages, master healers, high priests, landed nobility  |
| Disreputable or shameful | Hedge witches, fortune-tellers, gravediggers, money-lenders |

♦ **Core: What work do most people do?**

*The baseline tells you what's normal, and normal is important because your characters' deviations from it are what create tension. If most people farm, a character who refuses to farm is making a statement.*

In an agrarian society, most people farm. In a trade economy, many are merchants, sailors, or craftspeople. What's the baseline?

YOUR ANSWER

### **What occupations exist in your world?**

List occupations that appear or matter in your story:

**Describe 2-3 key occupations in your world. For each, what do they do, what is their social status, and who typically does this work?**

*(Write your answer below)*

### **What work is considered beneath certain people?**

*Class-based work taboos reveal a world's values. If a noble can't be seen doing manual labour, or a mage refuses healing work because it's "servant's magic," those taboos become walls between characters from different backgrounds.*

YOUR ANSWER

### What dangerous or unpleasant work exists?

*Dangerous work creates specific romantic tension: the fear of loss, the physical toll on the body, the secrecy about what the job really involves. If your character does dangerous work, their partner lives with that fear. Mining? Soldiering? Magical labour with costs? Work that shortens lives?*

YOUR ANSWER

### How People Enter Occupations

#### How do people end up in their occupations?

*The path into work shapes your characters' backstories and creates constraints. A character locked into a trade by birth has different options than one who chose their profession, and different resentments.*

| PATH INTO WORK                            | EXISTS IN YOUR WORLD?                                     | WHO TAKES THIS PATH   | ROMANTIC IMPLICATIONS                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Born into it (family trade, caste)</i> | <i>Yes:<br/>blacksmith families,<br/>farming families</i> | <i>Most commoners</i> | <i>Character can't leave their work to be with someone from another world</i> |

| PATH INTO WORK        | EXISTS IN YOUR WORLD? | WHO TAKES THIS PATH | ROMANTIC IMPLICATIONS |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|-----------------------|
| Apprenticeship        |                       |                     |                       |
| Education/academy     |                       |                     |                       |
| Military/conscription |                       |                     |                       |
| Magical selection     |                       |                     |                       |
| Economic necessity    |                       |                     |                       |
| Other:                |                       |                     |                       |

### Can people change occupations?

*If your protagonist is stuck in a job they hate, can they leave? If leaving means losing everything (guild membership, family ties, their only income), that's a constraint the romance has to navigate.*

Is mobility possible, or are you locked into your work for life?

YOUR ANSWER

### **How is labour organised in your world?**

*Guilds, unions, apprenticeship systems, military conscription, indentured service. These structures that control who can do what work also control who your characters can become. A guild that forbids outsiders is a wall between lovers from different trades. A conscription system decides your character's future for them.*

YOUR ANSWER

*Cross-check: Does your technology level (Section 9) support these types of work? A pre-industrial world probably doesn't have factory labour, and a high-magic world may have replaced certain trades entirely.*

### **♦ Core: What does your protagonist do to survive?**

Work shapes who we become. What skills, knowledge, and worldview has their occupation given them?

**Describe your protagonist's occupation: What do they do? What skills have they learned through work? How does the work show on their body? What do they notice that others don't because of their training?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What does your love interest do to survive?**

How does their work connect to or conflict with your protagonist's world? Do their occupations create proximity or distance?

**Describe your love interest's occupation: What do they do? What skills have they learned through work? How does the work show on their body? What do they notice that others don't because of their training?**

*(Write your answer below)*



◆ **Checkpoint: World and Work**

*Pause and look at your answers so far. Do your characters' occupations make sense within the economic system you built? Does the work they do match the world's resources, trade routes, and class structure? If a character is a merchant in a world with no trade routes, or a mage in an economy that doesn't value magic, now's a good time to adjust before moving on.*



## Your Characters' Economic Positions

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### ♦ Core: Where does your protagonist fall economically?

Their economic position shapes what they worry about, what they dream of, and what they would sacrifice for security or freedom.

**Describe your protagonist's economic position: What is their economic status, source of income, economic security, and economic autonomy?**

*(Write your answer below)*

### Where does your love interest fall economically?

How does their economic reality differ from your protagonist's? What assumptions do they make about money that might clash or align?

**Describe your love interest's economic position: What is their economic status, source of income, economic security, and economic autonomy?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**If there's a gap, how significant is it?**

Minor difference? Significant gap? Extreme disparity?

YOUR ANSWER

## The Wealth Gap Dynamic

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If your characters have different socio-economic statuses, show the gap through concrete details: the wealthy character casually ordering something the other couldn't afford in a month, the poor character flinching at prices. Show both perspectives: the wealthy character's obliviousness and the poor character's survival knowledge the wealthy one lacks. When the wealth gap causes tension, give the characters time to struggle with pride, obligation, and doubt.

**What can the wealthier character provide that the other can't access alone?**

Safety? Comfort? Opportunity? Legal protection? Social access?

YOUR ANSWER

**What does the less wealthy character bring that money can't buy?**

Skills? Knowledge? Magical ability? Street smarts? Moral clarity?

YOUR ANSWER

**Who holds the power because of the wealth gap, and how do they use it?**

Does one depend on the other? Is there resentment? Does the wealthy one use money as control?

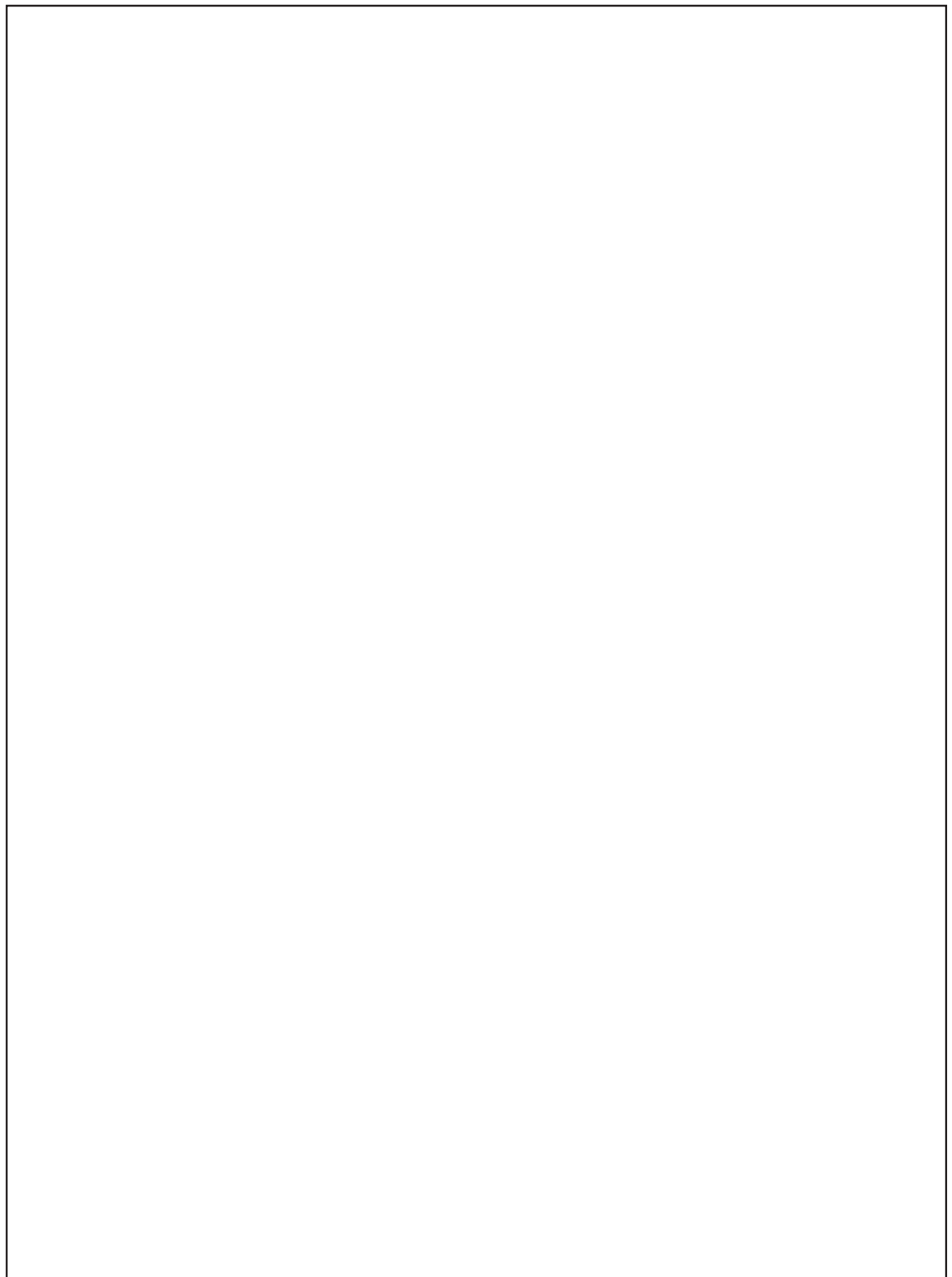
YOUR ANSWER

**How do they each feel about the gap?**

Shame? Guilt? Obliviousness? Resentment? These feelings may never be spoken aloud, but they shape every interaction.

**How does each character feel about the wealth gap between them, and how do they show it (or hide it)?**

*(Write your answer below)*



## Money, Gifts & What They Mean

Money and gifts between romantic partners are never simple. For the giver, a gift can be an expression of care or a substitute for harder things. For the receiver, it can feel like love made tangible or like charity. The most effective gift scenes focus not on expensive objects but on being seen. The gift that says “I noticed what you needed” carries more romantic weight than a chest of gold.

**What does it mean in your culture for one person to give money or expensive gifts to another?**

Romantic? Controlling? Insulting? Expected? Does meaning differ based on who gives and who receives?

YOUR ANSWER

**Where is the line between a generous gift and buying someone?**

*In your world’s culture, what separates a thoughtful gesture from an uncomfortable display of wealth? The answer might differ depending on who’s giving and who’s receiving.*

YOUR ANSWER

**If the wealthier character offers to pay for something, how does the other feel?**

Grateful? Humiliated? Obligated? Suspicious of motives?

YOUR ANSWER

**What would it mean for the less wealthy character to refuse help?**

Pride? Independence? Proving the relationship isn't about money? What would they sacrifice by refusing?

YOUR ANSWER

**Has money created a misunderstanding or conflict between your characters?**

A gift taken wrong? An offer that insulted? A refusal that hurt?

YOUR ANSWER

**What financial gesture would be genuinely romantic, not transactional?**

Not buying something expensive, but noticing what they need and providing it without being asked. The gesture that says "I see you" rather than "I can afford this."

YOUR ANSWER



# Marriage as Economic Contract

In most romantasy worlds, marriage isn't just about love. It's a financial transaction, a political alliance, a transfer of property and power. This collision between what the heart wants and what the contract demands is one of the genre's most potent sources of tension. When marriage has a price, love has a cost.

*See also: Government, Power & Law: Marriage Laws and Political Arrangements for the legal and political dimensions.*

In romantasy, marriage contracts can go beyond financial transactions. Magical bonds, spiritual bindings, or supernatural punishments for breaking terms raise the stakes far beyond what historical fiction allows. The core tension remains the disconnect between contractual obligation and genuine feeling. Characters may also use the contract to achieve agency: binding rather than being bound, accepting a proposal not for love but for freedom or power.

## ♦ Core: What is marriage worth in your world?

How is marriage negotiated? What does each party bring to the arrangement, and what do they stand to lose?

**Describe the economics of marriage in your world: Who negotiates? What does each side provide (dowry, bride price, alliance)? What happens financially if the marriage dissolves?**

*(Write your answer below)*

## **Is your protagonist's marriage being negotiated for economic reasons?**

If so, the romance is fighting against a contract. That contract needs teeth: real consequences for breaking it. Lost land, broken alliances, financial ruin for a family, magical backlash, a soul forfeit. The stronger the contract's grip, the higher the stakes for choosing love instead.

## **How does your protagonist navigate the contract?**

Does she submit to it, subvert it, or use it as a tool for her own goals? The answer shapes what kind of heroine she is, and what kind of romance you're writing.

| STRATEGY            | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE                                   | WHAT IT COSTS                                                                 |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Accept and redefine | Enter the arrangement, then transform it from within | Risk of losing yourself to the role; the line between performing and becoming |
| Refuse and rebel    | Reject the contract entirely, face the consequences  | Financial ruin, exile, loss of family protection                              |
| Game the system     | Use the contract's own rules to achieve your goals   | Moral compromise; the danger of becoming what you're fighting against         |

**If your world uses magical contracts or bonds, define the terms:**

**If your characters are bound by a contract, bargain, or magical bond: What kind of bond is it? Who initiated it and why? What are the exact terms? What happens if someone breaks it? Is consummation required? Can the bond be felt physically or mentally?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What does the contract force them to do that they wouldn't choose freely?**

Forced proximity only creates tension if it's genuinely forced. What specific obligation does the contract impose: living together, appearing in public as a couple, physical contact, sharing information?

**At what moment does the contract stop being the reason they stay?**

This is the romantic turning point. The obligation hasn't changed, but the motivation has. When does "I have to be here" become "I want to be here"?

YOUR ANSWER

### **Inheritance & Economic Marriage**

**What does each character stand to inherit?**

**What does each character stand to inherit, or what have they been denied?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**Does marrying the “right” or “wrong” person affect inheritance?**

**Can they be disinherited? Do they inherit more for marrying strategically?**

YOUR ANSWER

**Does your culture have dowries, bride prices, or marriage payments?**

Who pays whom, and how does this create obstacles?

YOUR ANSWER

**Is either character being pressured to marry for economic reasons?**

By whom? What would they lose by refusing?

YOUR ANSWER

---

**◆ Checkpoint: Contracts and Constraints**

*Pause and look at your answers so far. Are the economic pressures on your romance consistent? If your character is being pressured into a marriage for money, does the wealth gap you established earlier explain why? If inheritance is at stake, does it connect to the class system you built? Make sure the personal stakes grow out of the world you've designed, not around it.*

## Debt, Obligation & Economic Coercion

Debt muddies the waters of consent. Every time one character owes another (money, a life debt, magical service, bonded labour), every interaction is shadowed by the question: are they choosing this freely, or because they have to? In romantasy, debt is often both literal and magical: bargain tattoos, supernatural obligations, souls signed as collateral. The best debt romances let both characters wrestle with the ambiguity rather than resolving it quickly.

### Is either character in debt?

Debt creates obligation, and obligation clouds consent. Does debt to the love interest (or a third party) complicate the romance?

**If a character carries a debt: To whom is it owed? For what? What happens if they can't repay? Is it magically enforced? How does the debt affect their ability to say yes or no to the romance?**

*(Write your answer below)*

### How does this debt affect the romance?

Does it force them together? Keep them apart? Create shame or obligation between them?

YOUR ANSWER

### Life Debts & Magical Obligations

**In your world, can saving someone's life create a binding debt?**

*A life debt between lovers poisons every tender moment with the question: is this gratitude or love? Name the debt so you can track how it shadows the romance.*

| TYPE OF LIFE DEBT   | DOES IT EXIST IN YOUR WORLD? | HOW IS IT ENFORCED? | HOW DOES IT END? |
|---------------------|------------------------------|---------------------|------------------|
| Cultural obligation |                              |                     |                  |
| Magical compulsion  |                              |                     |                  |
| Legal requirement   |                              |                     |                  |
| Other:              |                              |                     |                  |

**Does either character owe such a debt, or is owed one?**

*If the answer is yes, every romantic gesture between them is shadowed by obligation. The reader needs to feel that shadow before the characters can step out of it.*

YOUR ANSWER

## Economic Arrangements

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**Could economic necessity force your characters into an arrangement?**

Marriage for money? Employment? Alliance for mutual benefit?

**If your characters have an economic arrangement (marriage of convenience, etc.), describe: What is the arrangement? Why is it necessary? What does each party get?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**How does each character deal with being pushed into this arrangement?**

Do they resent it? Accept it? Try to escape it? Fall in love despite it, or struggle to trust their feelings because of it?

YOUR ANSWER

**The “Buying” Problem**

Could the wealthy character simply buy their way out of obstacles? If yes, why don't they?

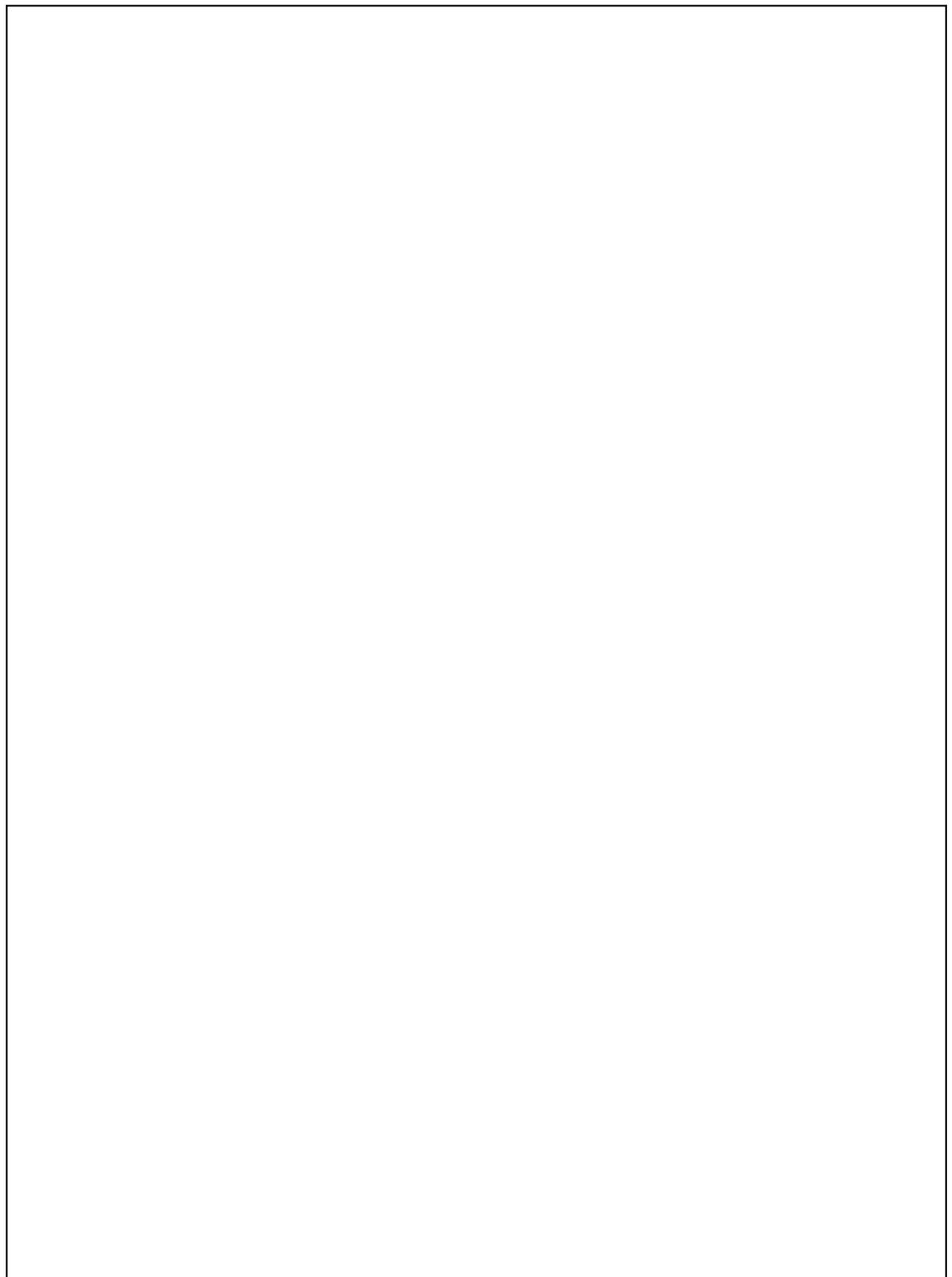


YOUR ANSWER

Could someone try to buy one of your characters, offer money to leave, marry someone else, betray their partner?

YOUR ANSWER

**If someone offered your character money to walk away from the relationship, what would they do?**  
*This question reveals what the relationship is really worth to each character. Think about who might make the offer: a disapproving parent, a rival, an employer, and what amount would even make your character hesitate. (Write your answer below)*



# The Employer & The Employed

When one character employs the other (bodyguard and monarch, healer and commander, governess and lord), work creates proximity, but it also creates a power dynamic. The employer can terminate, punish, or destroy the employee's livelihood. If you're writing this dynamic, you need to address the imbalance directly.

**Does one character employ the other?**

**If one character employs the other: Who employs whom? What is the nature of the employment? Can the employee leave freely? What would they lose by refusing advances? What would they lose by accepting?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What type of binding keeps the employee in place, and can they leave?**

| BINDING TYPE                    | CAN THEY LEAVE?                                        | HOW YOU'LL SHOW CONSENT IS REAL |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Hired for wages                 | Yes, but may lose livelihood                           |                                 |
| Bonded service / apprenticeship | Not without cost: loss of magic, status, or protection |                                 |
| Institutional conscription      | No: the institution owns their service                 |                                 |
| Magical contract / soul oath    | No: breaking the bond has supernatural consequences    |                                 |

**How does the less powerful character demonstrate genuine choice?**

*The reader needs evidence that the less powerful character is choosing freely. Consider: Do they develop feelings independently of the power dynamic? Does the powerful character prove that “no” has no consequences? Does the less powerful character hold moral authority the other needs?*

YOUR ANSWER

**What would it cost the employee to walk away, and what would it cost them to stay?**

| IF THEY WALK AWAY                                                                  | IF THEY STAY                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What do they lose? (income, protection, access, proximity to the person they want) | What do they risk? (reputation, autonomy, being seen as bought)   |
| What do they gain? (freedom, self-respect, independence)                           | What do they gain? (security, closeness, the relationship itself) |

## **Economic Independence & Dependence**

**Before the relationship, how economically independent is each character?**

**How economically independent is each character? Could they survive on their own?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What changes about each character's financial life because of the relationship?**

*Does one gain security they never had? Does one lose independence they took for granted? The economic shift that comes with partnership can feel like rescue or like a trap, sometimes both at once.*

YOUR ANSWER

**If one becomes economically dependent on the other, how do they feel about it?**

Secure? Trapped? Grateful? Resentful? Anxious about what happens if the relationship ends?

YOUR ANSWER

**What would each character do if the relationship ended?**

Could they survive financially? Would they be ruined? Is economic fear part of what keeps them together?

YOUR ANSWER

**What power does the provider hold, and do they know it?**

*Economic dependence gives the provider leverage whether they want it or not. Does the dependent partner resent it? Does the provider use it, consciously or not?*

YOUR ANSWER

## Labour & Occupation in Romance

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What people do for work isn't just how they earn money. It's how they spend most of their waking hours, what skills they develop, and often how they see themselves.

*You've already mapped your characters' occupations and economic positions in the exercises above. Now focus on how their work shapes the romance itself: the daily rhythms, the proximity or distance, and the friction between their professional worlds.*

**Where and when can your characters actually see each other, given their jobs?**

*Same workplace? Completely separate worlds? Does one employ the other? Do their schedules mean they can only meet at midnight? The logistics of work create the logistics of love.*

YOUR ANSWER

**What work does either character hide or feel ashamed of?**

*Shameful work carries a specific kind of romantic weight. If the love interest discovers what the protagonist really does, is that a betrayal of trust or an invitation to deeper intimacy? The shame shapes what they hide and what they reveal.*



YOUR ANSWER

## Ambition & Economic Striving

**Is either character trying to improve their economic position?**

*Ambition is a romantic complication all on its own. A character who's climbing socially or financially is making choices about where to spend their time, who to be seen with, and what risks to take, and a love interest can either accelerate that climb or derail it entirely.*

What are they striving for, and why?

YOUR ANSWER

**What does ambition cost the relationship?**

*Ambition steals hours, demands compromises, and creates priorities that compete with love. But it also makes a character attractive. There's real romantic heat in watching someone pursue something with everything they have.*

Does it compete for time and attention? Does the relationship help or hinder their goals? Could loving the "wrong" person cost them everything they're working toward?

YOUR ANSWER

**Where is the line between love and a good deal?**

*If marrying the love interest would also solve your character's financial problems, both characters will wonder, maybe privately, maybe out loud, whether love and ambition are the same feeling. The reader should wonder too, at least for a while.*

How would each character answer the question "Is this love or is this a good deal?"

**What does each character tell themselves about the economic dimension of the relationship, and what are they afraid might actually be true?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What would they sacrifice (the relationship or the ambition) if forced to choose?**

*This is the test. If you can't answer it, neither can your character, and that indecision is itself a source of tension you can use.*

YOUR ANSWER

## Economic Sacrifice

---

Economic sacrifice proves love is real in a way words can't. Make the sacrifice concrete and visible. Not just "gave up the inheritance" but the smaller apartment, the mended clothes, the dinner that's mostly bread. Economic sacrifice is most powerful when it's ongoing, not a one-time grand gesture.

**What economic security does each character sacrifice to be together?**

What inheritance, income, protection, or opportunity do they lose by choosing each other? The sacrifice should cost enough to prove the love is real.

**What does each character sacrifice economically to be together?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**Is the sacrifice permanent or temporary?**

*A temporary sacrifice is a dramatic gesture. A permanent one is a life sentence. The permanence determines whether the sacrifice is a plot beat or the foundation of their entire future together.*

Can they recover economically?

YOUR ANSWER

**How do they survive after the sacrifice?**

*This is where romance meets reality. The grand gesture happened. Now what? Rent is due. The pantry is empty. Show what love looks like when the money runs out.*

YOUR ANSWER

### **Does the sacrifice create resentment or guilt?**

*Even a sacrifice made freely can curdle. The one who gave something up may resent it on a bad day. The one who benefited may feel guilty they can't match it. This ongoing tension is more interesting than the sacrifice itself.*

YOUR ANSWER

*But the sacrifice doesn't end at the climax. Keep reading. The ongoing costs of choosing love are where the best romance writing lives.*

### **What Happens After They Choose Each Other?**

The sacrifices don't stop at the climax. If a character gave up an inheritance, they still need to eat next week. When a couple crosses class lines, the world withdraws its business: social ostracism, lost patronage, closed professional networks. Disinheritance leads to permanent downward mobility, where characters retain the expectations of their former life but not the means. And partners from different economic backgrounds bring clashing money habits that don't disappear just because they're in love.

| CONSEQUENCE          | HOW IT AFFECTS THEM                                       | QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE                                                                |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Social ostracism     | Lost patronage, closed doors, professional ruin           | Whose social world do they live in now? Who still accepts them?                          |
| Disinheritance       | Loss of estate, title, family support                     | What do they actually live on? What standard of living can they maintain?                |
| Downward mobility    | The daily reality of having less than they're used to     | What does the character who "married down" miss most? What surprises them about poverty? |
| Money habit friction | Different spending patterns, different fears about money  | Does one partner hoard while the other spends? Who controls the household budget?        |
| Impact on children   | Children inherit the social stigma of the parents' choice | Will their children have access to the world one parent left behind?                     |

### What does daily life look like after the sacrifice?

Don't skip this. The most powerful romantic endings show the cost in concrete, daily terms. Map what changes for each character.

**After your characters choose each other over economic security: Where do they live? What do they eat every day? Who do they still have access to? Who has shut them out? What do they miss most? What surprised them about their new reality?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**How do they handle money differently?**

Partners from different backgrounds will clash over spending. This isn't a flaw to fix. It's a source of ongoing, realistic tension that makes the relationship feel lived-in.

**How do your characters' different financial backgrounds show up in daily life? For the one who grew up with less and the one with more: What do they spend freely on? What do they refuse to spend on? What purchase would start an argument? How do they feel about accepting help?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What moment makes the sacrifice feel worth it?**

*This is your earned ending. Not the wedding, not the declaration. It's the quiet scene where reduced circumstances feel like the right choice. Make it small and specific, and it'll hit harder than any grand gesture. There should be a scene, maybe small, maybe private, where one character looks at their reduced circumstances and feels certain they chose right. What does that moment look like?*





### ◆ Checkpoint: The Cost of Love

*Pause and look at your answers so far. Do the sacrifices your characters make feel proportional to the economic world you've built? If you said class is rigid and mobility is impossible, does the sacrifice reflect that, or does it feel too easy? If you established a harsh economy, the aftermath of choosing love should show that harshness. Make sure the consequences match the world.*

## Poverty, Survival & Desperation

---

**What does your less wealthy character need to survive?**

Immediate needs:

YOUR ANSWER

**How do they currently meet these needs?**

HOW DO THEY CURRENTLY MEET THESE NEEDS?

**What happens if they can't?**

Starvation? Homelessness? Forced into servitude? Death?

YOUR ANSWER

*What would they do to survive? How far would they go?*

WHAT WOULD THEY DO TO SURVIVE? HOW FAR WOULD THEY GO?

**Has desperation forced them into their current situation?**

A job they hate? Dangerous work? An arrangement they don't want?

YOUR ANSWER

**Does the love interest offer economic security?**

If yes, does this complicate the romance? Create doubt about true feelings?

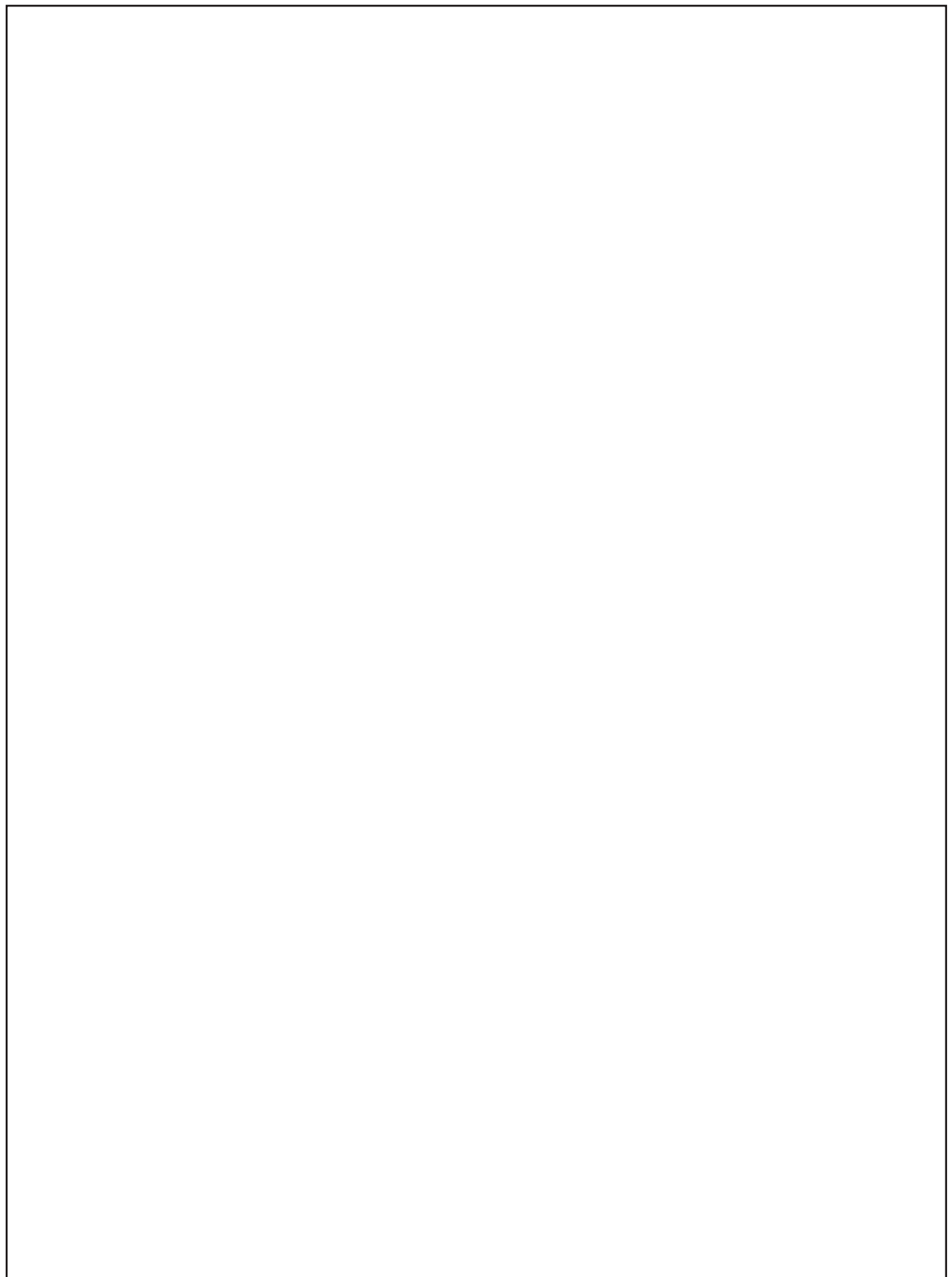
YOUR ANSWER

**What desperate choice has survival pressure forced onto the romance?**

*Desperation doesn't just create backstory. It creates present-tense romantic tension. A character who can't eat tomorrow makes different choices about love than one who's comfortable.*

**Describe a specific survival pressure, how it bends the relationship, and a scene where the reader can feel it.**

*(Write your answer below)*



# Smuggling, Black Markets & Underground Economies

If you're writing a character who operates outside the law (smuggler, thief, black-market dealer), the underground economy is a structural element in how they live, who they can trust, and what they can offer a romantic partner.

## How Does Your Underground Economy Work?

If either character operates in a shadow economy, you need to know how it functions. Not every detail, but enough that the criminal world feels like a system rather than a set of isolated crimes.

| ELEMENT                    | WHAT TO DECIDE                                                                    | WHY IT MATTERS FOR ROMANCE                                                                                              |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What's traded?             | Contraband, stolen goods, information, magical substances, people, assassinations | The moral weight of what your character sells determines how much redemption the romance needs to carry                 |
| Who controls the routes?   | Ports, tunnels, inter-world crossings, auction houses, guild halls                | Chokepoints are where tension concentrates, and where lovers must rely on each other to survive                         |
| How is trust enforced?     | Reputation, violence, oaths, magical contracts, codes of conduct                  | Criminal trust systems double as romantic constraints: "no questions," "no attachments," vows that forbid vulnerability |
| What does failure cost?    | Death, exposure, loss of territory, betrayal by allies                            | The stakes of the criminal life are the stakes of the love story                                                        |
| How does the law interact? | Corrupt officials, selective enforcement, raids, informants                       | If guards are omniscient when you need a chase and blind when you need a kiss, the world falls apart                    |

In the best underground-economy romances, the criminal infrastructure is visible and specific (routes, chokepoints, codes of conduct), and the romance is built on the same logic: staged disclosure, controlled vulnerability, trust as a calculated risk.

## Secrecy & Morality

In criminal romances, information is both a commodity and an intimacy marker. Revealing a real name, a route, or a weakness is an economic concession as much as an emotional one. The romantic turning point often comes when one character reveals something that makes them completely vulnerable.

If your characters profit from an underground economy, the romance needs to confront that reality. The strongest criminal romances put characters at a fork where both paths cost something real: profit versus protecting the vulnerable, loyalty to crew versus loyalty to partner.

**What moral choice does the underground economy force on your romance?**

*“Morally grey” isn’t a personality trait. It’s a decision in a specific moment. The best criminal romances put the character at a fork where both paths cost something real. What’s the fork for your character, and what does their choice reveal about what they value more than profit?*

**Describe a moral fork your character faces: two options, both costly. What do they choose, what does it cost, and what does it reveal to their partner?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**Does either character operate outside the law?**

**If a character is involved in criminal activity: What illegal activity? What organisation? What code governs their criminal world? What would their lover lose by association? What moral line would they refuse to cross?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What is the chokepoint in your criminal world?**

Every convincing underground economy has a bottleneck: a port, a tunnel, a border crossing, an auction house, a guild hall. It's where power concentrates and where your characters are most vulnerable. What is it, and who controls it?

**How does secrecy shape the romance?**

If one character operates outside the law, they're keeping secrets. Map the disclosure arc: what do they withhold, what do they reveal, and when does revealing a secret become the romantic turning point?

**Describe how the criminal character's walls come down across three stages (early, middle, turning point): What are they hiding, what do they reveal, and what does each revelation cost them?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**What does the non-criminal partner discover, and how do they react?**

If your love interest isn't part of the criminal world, the moment they find out is a make-or-break scene. What specifically do they learn? Are they horrified, fascinated, or both? Does it change what they thought they knew about the person they love?

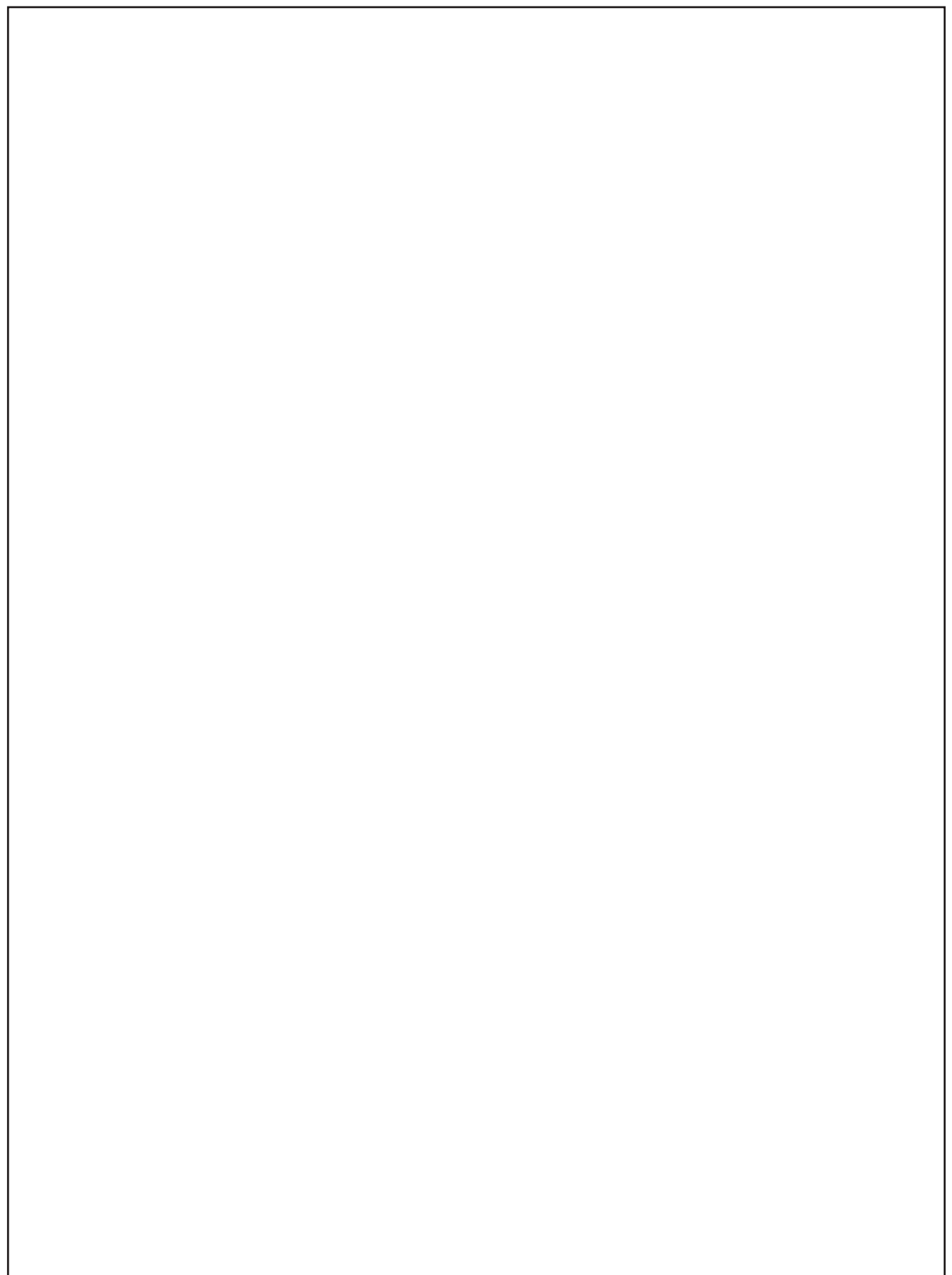
**What would going legitimate cost them?**

Some criminal romances end with the characters leaving the life. But leaving has a price: lost allies, lost income, lost identity. If your characters went straight, what would they lose?

**If your criminal character went legitimate, what would they lose and what would they gain?**

*(Write your answer below)*





## Apply the Principle: The Invisible Ledger & Your Romance

You've now built the economic foundation of your world: the systems, currency, class structures, occupations, and pressures that shape daily life. With that foundation in place, it's time to return to the Invisible Ledger principle from the opening of this section and apply it directly to your characters and their romance.

Consider what the Invisible Ledger reveals in your romance:

- **Who owes more?** At the start of your story, which character has received more than they can repay? How does that debt change their behaviour? Are they more guarded, more eager to prove themselves, more resentful?
- **What can't be repaid with money?** A life saved, a secret kept, a reputation protected. These are debts that money can't settle, and that's where the tension lives.
- **Where does helping start to feel like owning?** There is a tipping point where "I'm helping you" starts to feel like "I own you." The recipient may not be able to define the difference, but they sense it. Where is that line for your characters?
- **What would balance the ledger?** What could the less powerful character offer or risk so their partner sees them as an equal? Sometimes it's competence. Sometimes it's emotional honesty. Sometimes it's the willingness to walk away, proving they're staying by choice.

### The Key Question

What's the single biggest entry on your characters' Invisible Ledger: the one debt, gift, or sacrifice that neither of them can forget? And what will it take for them to stop letting it define the relationship?

#### ♦ Core: What's on your characters' Invisible Ledger?

**Map the emotional debt between your characters. What has been given or received, who gave, who owes, and how does the debt feel?**

*(Write your answer below)*

**When does the ledger stop mattering?**

What moment, scene, or choice makes one or both characters decide they're done keeping score? This is your romantic turning point. Make it earn its weight.



## Economic Tensions Synthesis

*You've already answered these questions in the exercises above. Pull your answers together here to see the full economic picture of your romance.*

| ELEMENT                                                                | YOUR ANSWER (FROM EARLIER EXERCISES) | SECTION TO REVIEW                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Economic system type                                                   |                                      | Economic Systems                                  |
| Protagonist's economic position                                        |                                      | Your Characters' Economic Positions               |
| Love interest's economic position                                      |                                      | Your Characters' Economic Positions               |
| Size of the wealth gap                                                 |                                      | Your Characters' Economic Positions               |
| Primary economic pattern<br>(wealth gap, debt, arrangement, sacrifice, |                                      | Wealth Gap / Debt / Marriage / Economic Sacrifice |

| ELEMENT                                                        | YOUR ANSWER (FROM EARLIER EXERCISES) | SECTION TO REVIEW                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| inheritance threat)                                            |                                      |                                           |
| Biggest entry on the Invisible Ledger                          |                                      | The Invisible Ledger                      |
| Key economic sacrifice                                         |                                      | Economic Sacrifice                        |
| What the sacrifice costs daily                                 |                                      | What Happens After They Choose Each Other |
| Does the romance reinforce or disrupt the economic status quo? |                                      |                                           |

## Integration Check

| QUESTION                                           | ANSWER | EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| How does government control or affect the economy? |        | <i>Entailment laws keep estates intact; the Crown grants trade monopolies; taxes fund wars that enrich some and bankrupt others</i> |

| QUESTION                                                                     | ANSWER | EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| How do cultural values affect economic behaviour?                            |        | <i>“Gentlemen don’t work” means heirs can’t earn; merchants are wealthy but not accepted; marrying for money is expected but admitting it is gauche</i> |
| Could magic solve your characters’ economic problems? Why don’t they use it? |        | <i>Transmutation is possible but illegal (counterfeiting); money spells are traceable; magical labour is regulated by guild</i>                         |
| How does economics interact with your political obstacles?                   |        | <i>He needs to marry an heiress to save the estate; she has money but not status. His family opposes her, but needs her dowry</i>                       |

## Quick Reference: Economic Stakes

| ELEMENT                               | YOUR WORLD | EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)                                                               |
|---------------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Type of economy                       |            | <i>Feudal with emerging merchant class: old money (land) vs. new money (trade)</i>         |
| Primary economic obstacle for romance |            | <i>She’s a servant; he’s heir to the estate. Their stations make marriage unthinkable.</i> |
| Economic power imbalance              |            | <i>He could fire her, evict her family, ruin her completely. She has no leverage</i>       |
| The valuable/scarce resource          |            | <i>Land: the estate represents generations of wealth and power</i>                         |

| ELEMENT                                    | YOUR WORLD | EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Who controls it                            |            | <i>His father, who will disinherit him if he marries beneath his station</i>                                |
| Economic debt or obligation                |            | <i>Her family owes debt to his; she works it off. He could forgive it, would that be rescue or control?</i> |
| Economic sacrifice required to be together |            | <i>He gives up his inheritance; they start with nothing but each other</i>                                  |

## Final Thought: Money Gets Personal

The question isn't "how does the tax system work?" It's "what would this character do if they couldn't eat tomorrow?"

Economics creates stakes when it forces impossible choices: love or survival? Pride or security?

Build an economy that makes these choices real.



### What's Next

Your economy is built. Here's where to take it:

- **If you haven't done Government yet** → Section 5 (Government, Power & Law) is the natural next step. Taxes, trade regulation, and power structures grow directly from economic foundations.
- **If your economy runs on magic** → Make sure your magic system (Section 8) is consistent with what you've built here, especially around scarcity, cost, and who controls magical labour.
- **If class divides your characters** → Section 3 (Culture, Customs & Daily Life) will help you flesh out how wealth shows up in clothing, food, manners, and social rituals.
- **If your world has scarce resources** → Section 1 (Geography & Environment) should align with where those resources come from and who controls the land.
- **Ready to stress-test?** → Section 16 (Web of Systems) will check how your economy interacts with everything else you've built.